

We'd bring new customers into our office. They'd customize the avatar and download the product like before. Then they would go into single-player mode, and we'd say, "Play with your avatar and dress it up; check out the cool moves it can make." Followed by, "Okay, you did that by yourself; now it's time to invite one of your friends." You can see what's coming. They'd say, "No way! This isn't cool." And we'd say, "Well, we told you it wasn't going to be cool! What is the point of a single-player experience for a social product?" See, we thought we should get a gold star just for listening to our customers. Except our customers still didn't like the product. They would look at us and say, "Listen, old man, you don't understand. What is the deal with this crazy business of inviting friends before I know if it's cool?" It was a total deal breaker.

Out of further desperation, we introduced a feature called ChatNow that allows you to push a button and be randomly matched with somebody else anywhere in the world. The only thing you have in common is that you both pushed the button at the same time. All of a sudden, in our customer service tests, people were saying, "Oh, this is fun!"

So we'd bring them in, they'd use ChatNow, and maybe they would meet somebody they thought was cool. They'd say, "Hey, that guy was neat; I want to add him to my buddy list. Where's my buddy list?" And we'd say, "Oh, no, you don't want a new buddy list; you want to use your regular AOL buddy list." Remember, this was how we planned to harness the interoperability that would lead to network effects and viral growth. Picture the customer looking at us, asking, "What do you want me to do exactly?" And we'd say, "Well, just give the stranger your AIM screen name so you can put him on your buddy list." You could see their eyes go wide, and they'd say, "Are you kidding me? A stranger on my AIM buddy list?" To which we'd respond, "Yes; otherwise you'd have to download a whole new IM client with a new buddy list." And they'd say, "Do you have any idea how many IM clients I already run?"

"No. One or two, maybe?" That's how many clients each of us in the office used. To which the teenager would say, "Duh! I run